I like to catch anomalies in numbers before they become entrenched financial problems, big or small. For the past fifteen years, my wife has kept every single receipt for every single purchase she has made, and every few weeks we match those purchases with the credit card bill, allocating every item. It's just too easy to let hidden charges, overcharges, mistakes, or financial anomalies get lost in the shuffle, especially in your personal finances. Consider that a while ago, I received a call from my bookkeeper, who noticed a significant rise in our family phone bill. It went from being in the hundreds to almost $1,000—in one month! We discovered the increase was due to exorbitant roaming charges my son and I incurred while on vacation. We got a little too enthusiastic about our new iPhones and forgot that our plan did not cover roaming abroad. I'll refrain from ranting about the robbery of roaming charges, and after receiving that ridiculous bill, I certainly had an instructive chat about them with my son. Negotiating down that bill, which was the size of a pamphlet, wasn't easy. But if you're vigilant and watch where your money is going, you can plug the hole before your hard-earned cash disappears down the drain.

So have I convinced you? Are you ready to work on your financial picture?

Money Mistake: You're in the Dark About Your Finances

THE FIX: KNOW YOUR 90-DAY NUMBER

Knowledge is power. To know your spending and saving habits, start by adding up all your earnings over the course of three months. I call this your 90-Day Number. One month doesn't tell you much. Addiction specialists say it takes about a month to notice entrenched patterns of thinking and behavior and a couple more to introduce better ones. When a recovering addict comes to a crossroads, he or she is often advised to go to recovery meetings of some sort or another. And the person is told to go to 90 meetings in 90 days. I'm not saying you're addicted to spending—some of you may be, while many of you